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AETHERIA INFRASTRUCTURE RESEARCH (AIR)

Organisation Profile

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Document Control

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ISMS Purpose	Satisfies ISO/IEC 27001:2022 Clause 4 — Context of the Organisation
Related Documents	AIR-ISMS-SCO-001 ISMS Scope Statement AIR-ISMS-POL-001 Information Security Policy AIR-ISMS-AST-001 Asset Inventory AIR-ISMS-RSK-002 Risk Register

1. Purpose of This Document

This document establishes the organisational context for AIR's Information Security Management System (ISMS). It records the internal and external factors that shape AIR's approach to information security, identifies the parties whose needs the ISMS must address, and provides the factual foundation on which all ISMS policies, risk assessments, and controls are based.

This document directly addresses ISO/IEC 27001:2022 Clause 4, which requires organisations to understand their context before determining the scope and design of their ISMS. It is the starting point of the ISMS document hierarchy and should be read before any other ISMS document.

2. Organisation Overview

2.1 Identity and Mission

Aetheria Infrastructure Research (AIR) is a European research organisation specialising in the analysis, modelling, and resilience assessment of critical infrastructure systems. Founded in 2018 and headquartered in Madrid, Spain, AIR works at the intersection of infrastructure engineering, geospatial data science, and applied artificial intelligence.

AIR's mission is to provide governments, regulators, and infrastructure operators with the analytical insight they need to understand, protect, and strengthen the systems that support modern society, from energy networks and transport corridors to water systems and digital communications infrastructure.

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AIR operates under a dual mandate: it conducts independent applied research funded by public-sector grants and government partnerships, and it develops proprietary AI-powered analytical tools that it licenses to infrastructure operators and national authorities. This dual model creates a complex information environment in which government-classified research data, commercially sensitive AI models, and third-party partner data must be managed simultaneously.

2.2 Legal and Corporate Structure

Attribute	Detail
Legal Name	Aetheria Infrastructure Research S.L.
Legal Form	Sociedad Limitada (private limited company), incorporated in Spain
Registered Address	Calle de Alcalá 189, 28009 Madrid, Spain
Company Registration	CIF: B-82547118 Registered with the Registro Mercantil de Madrid
Founded	2018
Ownership	Privately held. Majority owned by founding partners. Minority institutional investment from a European deep-tech fund.
Revenue Model	Government research contracts (~55%) AI platform licensing (~30%) Consultancy and advisory (~15%)
Regulatory Jurisdiction	Spain (primary) EU regulatory frameworks apply across all operations
EU VAT Number	ESB82547118

2.3 Locations

Office	Role	Address	Headcount
Madrid HQ	Primary headquarters. Executive leadership, research operations, IT infrastructure, on-premises data repositories.	Calle de Alcalá 189, 28009 Madrid, Spain	98 staff
Brussels	EU policy and partnerships office. Government relations, legal, regulatory affairs.	Avenue Louise 54, 1050 Brussels, Belgium	27 staff
Riga	AI Engineering hub. Model development, AI platform engineering, research collaboration.	Skolas iela 45, 29249 Riga, Latvia	20 staff

All three offices operate under a unified IT environment managed from Madrid HQ. Remote working is supported across all locations. Field research activities occur at infrastructure sites across Europe, typically involving staff from Madrid and Riga.

2.4 Workforce

Category	Count	Access Profile	Typical Data Access
Permanent Employees	120	Full Entra ID accounts. Managed endpoints. Standard and elevated roles per department.	Internal to Restricted, depending on role
Contractors and Research Collaborators	25	Entra ID guest or member accounts scoped to engagement. Managed or compliant device required for Restricted access.	Internal to Restricted, depending on project
External Partners (no system access)	Variable	No AIR system access. Data shared via approved secure transfer channels only.	Receives AIR outputs only, no access to source data
Total Headcount	145	—	—

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3. Products and Services

3.1 Research and Analysis

AIR's core research activity focuses on the structural and systemic vulnerability of critical infrastructure networks. Research outputs include classified analysis reports, geospatial risk models, and scenario assessments delivered to government clients. Current active research programmes include:

- National energy grid vulnerability assessment — commissioned by a Latvian federal agency
- Cross-border transport corridor resilience modelling — EU Horizon-funded consortium
- Urban water network failure cascade analysis — partnership with a Spanish national authority
- Satellite communications infrastructure risk taxonomy — NATO-adjacent advisory programme

Research data produced under these programmes is classified **Restricted** or **Confidential** under AIR's information classification standard, and is subject to specific data handling obligations defined in individual research agreements.

3.2 AI Platform and Tools

AIR develops and operates a suite of AI-powered analytical tools under the internal product name ARIA (Aetheria Resilience Intelligence Architecture). ARIA components include:

- isMap — a geospatial AI model for infrastructure interdependency mapping and failure propagation simulation
- RealRisk — a machine learning model for dynamic risk scoring of infrastructure assets based on real-time sensor and open-source data
- CascadeML — a graph neural network model for cascade failure prediction across interconnected infrastructure networks

ARIA model weights, training datasets, and inference infrastructure are classified **Restricted**. Model deployment occurs exclusively within AIR's Azure environment (air-prod tenant). Licensing agreements with external operators provide API access to inference endpoints only. No model weights or training data are shared externally.

3.3 Advisory and Consultancy

AIR provides expert advisory services to governments, regulators, and infrastructure operators. Advisory outputs are typically **Confidential** and governed by individual engagement contracts. Advisory work frequently involves access to client-provided operational data, which is handled under data processing agreements aligned with GDPR.

4. Technology Landscape

AIR operates a cloud-first technology environment centred on Microsoft Azure and the Microsoft 365 productivity suite. The following systems form the primary technology landscape within the ISMS scope.

System / Platform	Purpose	Classification of Data Processed	Asset IDs
Microsoft Azure (air-prod tenant)	Cloud infrastructure, ML workloads (Azure Machine Learning), blob storage for research data, virtual networks, and identity services.	Restricted — Confidential	SA-001, SA-002, SA-003
Microsoft Entra ID	Identity and access management. Single sign-on, MFA, Conditional Access, Privileged Identity Management.	Confidential (identity data)	SA-004
Microsoft 365	Email (Exchange Online), Teams, SharePoint, OneDrive. Primary collaboration and communication platform.	Internal — Confidential	SA-005, SA-006

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GitHub Enterprise (org: airtech)	Source code hosting for ARIA models, internal tools, and research pipelines. Branch protection and audit logging enabled.	Restricted — Confidential	SA-007
On-Premises Research Repositories (Madrid HQ)	Legacy research datasets and field data not yet migrated to Azure. Physical access restricted to IT Operations.	Restricted	SA-008
Microsoft Intune	Mobile device management for 145 managed Windows endpoints. Enforces BitLocker, screen lock, update, and compliance policies.	Internal (device telemetry)	SA-009
Jira and Confluence	Project management and internal knowledge base. Hosted on Atlassian Cloud.	Internal — Confidential	SA-010, SA-011
Azure Key Vault	Secrets management for application credentials, API keys, and certificates.	Restricted (credential data)	SA-012

Personal devices are not within the ISMS scope and are not permitted to access Restricted or Confidential systems unless accessing AIR's Azure Virtual Desktop environment or passing a device compliance check via Conditional Access.

5. Departments and Organisational Structure

AIR is organised into six departments, each headed by a Director or Head who reports to the Chief Executive Officer.

Department	Head	Primary Location	Core Function	Headcount
Executive Leadership	Chief Executive Officer	Madrid	Strategic direction, government relations, investor reporting.	4
Infrastructure Analytics	Head of Infrastructure Analytics	Madrid	Delivery of government research programmes. Geospatial analysis, scenario modelling, client-facing research outputs.	42
AI Engineering	Head of AI Engineering	Riga	Design, training, and deployment of ARIA AI models. Research software engineering.	28
IT Operations	Head of IT Operations	Madrid	Infrastructure management, endpoint fleet, cloud operations, helpdesk, security tooling.	18
Legal & Partnerships	Head of Legal & Partnerships	Brussels	Contract management, GDPR compliance, government partnership agreements, procurement, supplier management.	14
Security & Compliance	Head of Security & Compliance	Madrid	ISMS ownership, risk management, internal audit, policy development, security awareness, incident coordination.	6
Programme Management	Programme Director	Madrid / Brussels	Cross-programme coordination, grant management, reporting to funders and government partners.	8

6. Interested Parties and Their Requirements

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ISO/IEC 27001:2022 Clause 4.2 requires AIR to identify the parties that are relevant to its ISMS and to understand their information security requirements. The following parties have been identified, along with the specific requirements they place on AIR's information security posture.

Interested Party	Relationship	Information Security Requirements
Government Research Partners (e.g. Latvian federal agency, national authorities)	Primary research clients and data providers. Grant funding and commission research.	Strict data classification and handling requirements. Contractual breach notification obligations (typically 24 hours). Right to audit AIR's data handling practices. Restrictions on data storage location and cross-border transfer.
European Commission / EU Funding Bodies	Horizon and other EU research grant funders.	Open data requirements for non-sensitive research outputs. Grant audit rights. GDPR compliance as a funding condition.
Infrastructure Operators (AI platform licensees)	Commercial licensees of ARIA inference APIs.	Data processing agreements. Service availability and confidentiality of inference inputs. No model weight disclosure.
Employees and Contractors	Internal workforce delivering AIR's mission.	Right to have personal data (HR records) handled lawfully under GDPR. Clear security obligations communicated and consistently enforced. Safe reporting channel for security concerns.
Regulatory Authorities	AEPD (Spain), IPGP (Latvia), relevant national data protection and cybersecurity authorities.	GDPR compliance (Articles 5, 25, 30, 32, 33, 34). NIS2 Directive obligations (as a provider of services to essential entities). Cooperation with supervisory authority investigations.
Certification Body	External auditor for ISO/IEC 27001:2022 certification.	Demonstrable, evidenced implementation of all applicable Annex A controls. Maintained and auditable ISMS documentation. Continuous improvement evidenced through audit findings and closure.
Suppliers and Sub-processors	Technology vendors, cloud providers, specialist contractors.	Contractual security obligations. GDPR Article 28 processor agreements. Incident notification to AIR within 24 hours of discovery.
Investors and Board	Minority institutional investor and founding partner shareholders.	Assurance that information security risk is managed proportionately. No incidents that would affect AIR's valuation or insurability.

7. Internal Context

ISO/IEC 27001:2022 Clause 4.1 requires AIR to understand the internal issues that are relevant to its purpose and that could affect its ability to achieve the intended outcomes of its ISMS.

7.1 Governance and Culture

- AIR has a flat management structure with six departments reporting directly to the CEO. Decision-making is centralised, which enables fast policy adoption but creates dependency on key individuals, particularly the Head of Security & Compliance.
- The organisation is research-led. Researchers and engineers prioritise delivery velocity, which can create tension with security controls that add friction to workflows. Security awareness and culture are at an early stage.
- Management commitment to information security is genuine and documented. The CEO has approved and signed the Information Security Policy and the ISMS investment has been formally budgeted.
- The Security & Compliance function was established in 2025. It is small (6 staff) relative to the organisation's risk profile and is still building authority and operational capability.

7.2 Strategic Objectives Relevant to the ISMS

The following strategic objectives directly influence the design and priorities of AIR's ISMS:

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Strategic Objective	ISMS Implication
Grow government research contract revenue by 40% by 2028.	New government partnerships will bring additional data handling obligations and audit rights. ISMS maturity is increasingly a prerequisite for contract award.
Achieve ISO/IEC 27001:2022 certification by Q1 2027.	The ISMS must reach a certifiable standard within the roadmap timeframe. This drives the prioritisation of the Security Improvement Roadmap (AIR-ISMS-RMP-001).
Expand ARIA platform to three new EU member state infrastructure operators by 2027.	Commercial expansion increases the volume of third-party data processed and the number of data processing agreements AIR must maintain.
Establish Riga as a Centre of Excellence for AI safety research.	AI Engineering growth increases the sensitivity of the IP held in GitHub Enterprise and Azure ML environments.
Reduce operational risk to government partnerships following the 2025 near-miss incident.	A near-miss involving a contractor account in late 2025 was the immediate catalyst for formalising the ISMS. Risk reduction in access control and offboarding is a top executive priority.

7.3 Known Internal Strengths

- Strong technical capability in cloud infrastructure: Azure skills are deep in IT Operations
- Microsoft technology stack provides rich security tooling (Defender, Purview, PIM, Intune) that is already partially deployed
- GitHub Enterprise audit logging provides strong visibility into source code activity
- Existing NDAs and contractual security clauses cover most of the workforce
- Executive leadership is engaged and committed, security is on the board agenda

7.4 Known Internal Weaknesses

- Security function is under-resourced relative to the organisation's risk profile and the volume of Restricted data held
- ISMS is in its first year: policies, procedures, and controls are not yet fully implemented or embedded in daily operations
- Offboarding and access lifecycle processes are manual and inconsistently followed
- Security awareness and training culture is immature, staff knowledge of classification requirements and incident reporting obligations is uneven
- No supplier security programme — a significant gap given the volume of third-party access to Restricted research data
- Distributed three-office structure creates physical and remote access security challenges that are not yet addressed

8. External Context

External issues that are relevant to AIR's purpose and that could affect its ISMS are identified across four domains: regulatory, threat, sector, and geopolitical.

8.1 Regulatory Environment

Regulation / Framework	Applicability to AIR	Key Obligations
GDPR (EU 2016/679)	Applies to all processing of personal data by AIR, including employee records, contractor data, and personal data collected during research.	Lawful basis for processing. Data subject rights. 72-hour breach notification to supervisory authority. Data Protection Impact Assessments. Record of Processing Activities.
NIS2 Directive (EU 2022/2555)	AIR provides analytical services and AI tools to operators of essential entities (energy,	Incident notification obligations. Supply chain security requirements. Risk management measures aligned to NIS2 Article 21. Potential

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	transport). As a managed service provider to these entities, AIR may fall within NIS2 scope as a significant entity.	registration with national competent authority.
EU AI Act (2024/1689)	ARIA models used for infrastructure risk assessment may be classified as high-risk AI systems under Annex III (critical infrastructure management).	Conformity assessment requirements. Transparency and explainability obligations. Risk management system for AI systems. Human oversight requirements.
Spanish National Security Scheme (ENS — Real Decreto 311/2022)	Applies if AIR processes data or provides services to Spanish public administration entities under research contracts.	Tiered security requirements based on data classification. Mandatory security controls aligned to ENS categories.
ISO/IEC 27001:2022	Voluntary certification target, required by several government partners as a condition of contract.	Full ISMS implementation. All 93 Annex A controls assessed in SoA. Continuous improvement and annual surveillance audits post-certification.

8.2 Threat Landscape

AIR's threat environment is materially elevated compared to a typical commercial organisation, due to the sensitivity of its research subject matter and the nature of its government partnerships.

Threat Category	Relevance to AIR	Risk Register Reference
Nation-State Espionage	AIR's critical infrastructure analysis outputs are of direct interest to foreign intelligence services. Attacks targeting government research partnerships are documented across the European research sector.	RSK-003, RSK-004, RSK-007
Ransomware	Research organisations with government ties are targeted by ransomware groups for both financial extortion and reputational damage to public-sector partners.	RSK-009
Supply Chain Compromise	AI model training pipelines and research software dependencies represent a potential supply chain attack vector. Contractor accounts are a documented vector in the sector.	RSK-001, RSK-008
Insider Threat	Research organisations face elevated insider risk from departing staff and contractors with access to IP. The 2025 near-miss incident involved a contractor account.	RSK-005, RSK-007
Phishing and Credential Theft	Targeted spear-phishing against research and public-sector staff is pervasive. Credential compromise is the most common initial access vector across the sector.	RSK-002

8.3 Sector and Competitive Context

- ISO/IEC 27001:2022 certification is becoming a standard procurement requirement for government research contracts in Latvia, Germany, Belgium, and Spain — markets AIR is actively growing in
- Several direct competitors have achieved or are pursuing certification, making it a competitive differentiator
- The European critical infrastructure research sector is experiencing increased regulatory scrutiny following high-profile incidents in 2023–2024, particularly in the energy and transport sectors
- EU AI Act implementation timelines are creating demand for AI risk assessment expertise, an opportunity for AIR that also increases regulatory exposure
- Research funding bodies are increasingly requiring data management plans and information security evidence as part of grant applications

8.4 Geopolitical Context

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AIR's research into critical infrastructure vulnerability is directly relevant to the current European security environment. Heightened geopolitical tension in Europe since 2022 has increased both the value of AIR's research to government partners and the attractiveness of AIR as a target for adversarial actors. This context elevates AIR's residual threat exposure above what would be expected for an organisation of its size and must be reflected in the ISMS risk appetite and control design.

9. ISMS Scope Summary

The full ISMS Scope Statement is documented in AIR-ISMS-SCO-001. The following is a summary for reference.

Scope Element	In Scope	Out of Scope
Locations	Madrid HQ Brussels office Riga office Remote working by AIR personnel from approved locations	Client sites Field research locations not operated by AIR
Systems	Azure (air-prod tenant) Microsoft 365 GitHub Enterprise Intune-managed endpoints Madrid HQ on-premises repositories Jira / Confluence Azure Key Vault	Personal devices Client-operated systems Third-party systems accessed by AIR staff (e.g. government portals)
Personnel	All permanent employees All contractors with AIR system access Research collaborators with AIR system access	Subcontractors without AIR system access External partners receiving outputs only
Information Assets	All primary and supporting assets documented in AIR-ISMS-AST-001, including PA-001 through PA-011 and SA-001 through SA-012	Information held solely by third parties that AIR cannot control
Services	Government research programme delivery ARIA AI platform operation Advisory and consultancy delivery	Personal use of AIR systems by staff outside working hours (covered by Acceptable Use Policy, not ISMS scope)

10. Key Dependencies and Constraints

The following dependencies and constraints have material implications for the design and operation of AIR's ISMS and are recorded here for the awareness of auditors, new staff, and ISMS reviewers.

Dependency / Constraint	Nature	ISMS Implication
Microsoft Azure and M365	Technical dependency	Most of AIR's security controls depend on Microsoft security tooling. A Microsoft platform outage or misconfiguration could affect multiple controls simultaneously.
Belgian federal agency data sharing agreement	Contractual constraint	The most restrictive data handling obligations in AIR's portfolio. Sets the effective minimum standard for Restricted data controls across the organisation.
GDPR / AEPD jurisdiction	Regulatory constraint	As a Spanish-registered company, AIR's lead supervisory authority is the AEPD. All GDPR notifications go to AEPD first, even for incidents affecting non-Spanish data subjects.
Small Security & Compliance team	Resource constraint	The 6-person Security & Compliance team cannot maintain the ISMS, run awareness programmes, manage incidents, and build new capabilities simultaneously without prioritisation trade-offs.
Research delivery timelines	Operational constraint	Government research deliverables create fixed deadlines that cannot be moved. Security controls that impede research delivery will face internal resistance and require executive-level escalation to enforce.
Contractor model	Workforce constraint	25 contractors with rotating engagement dates create a continuous offboarding challenge. Until automated deprovisioning is in place, manual processes introduce persistent risk.

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11. Approval

Role	Name	Signature	Date
Document Owner	Head of Security & Compliance		May 2026
Executive Approver	Chief Executive Officer		May 2026